

School of Computer Science

Research Ethics Committee (CS REC)



SOP 2.2: Taught Student AI/ML with Text Data

Standard Operating Procedure (SOP) for AI/ML with personal data, including text and social media data.

This form is a version of the CS REC ethics application form 2, for use by taught students conducting a project involving AI/ML with Text Corpora downloaded from a public repository by the student or provided by the project supervisor.

Note that there are a number of other SOPs for other types of project activity on the CS Ethics Sharepoint site. You can submit more than one ethics application for a single taught project if it has different elements that involve participants and/or personal data. If your work doesn't fit one of the SOPs then you should complete the appropriate standard ethics application form and submit it to the CS Research Ethics Committee for review.

The student:

- Must edit the **yellow highlighted** (variable) sections in line with the specific details of their project.
 - o Specific prompts are included in square brackets and should be replaced as appropriate, e.g. "[student name]" should be replaced with your name! (Leave it highlighted but remove the square brackets.)
- Must NOT edit any other text.
- Must read through the risk checklists (section A part 5) and confirm that the project does NOT include any of the risk factors in the list.
- Must get their project supervisor to check and confirm their changes and level of risk BEFORE starting to recruit or work with participants or personal data.

Note that you should remove any yellow highlights and italic text from Part B before sending it to data subjects (if relevant).

If your project requires you change any other text or any of the risk checklist items then you should identify these changes in section A.4 and arrange for your application to be reviewed by the CS REC. If you are unsure then ask your supervisor or someone on the CS Ethics REC for advice. (Project supervisors can no longer review non-standard applications.)

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Ethics application for research where personal data is NOT obtained directly from participants.

This form should be used if the research processes personal data that are not obtained directly from the participants involved in the research. For example, if data is provided by a company or is publicly available in an online database. Note, for a dataset from a public repository or online database, only use datasets with a documented collection process (e.g. in an associated scientific paper) and the collection process should be evaluated *before* the data is used.

If you are not sure what personal data is or what processing personal data means, see *READ ME (does my research require ethics approval?)*

Sections A and B of this form must be completed and receive a favourable ethical opinion (FEO) ***before*** data is obtained and processed.

Sections A and B should be completed by the researcher. Check/Complete all sections. Edit **highlighted texts only. Do NOT modify this form prior to ethics review.**

Section B should be provided to the data subjects (the people who the data is about), **wherever possible**. It may be modified (e.g., non-applicable sub-sections deleted or formatted for publication online) after the application has been approved.

The principal investigator or supervisor should sign-off this ethics application and submit the completed form to Ps-cs-ethicsadmin@exmail.nottingham.ac.uk.

The principal investigator or supervisor is responsible for ensuring the application has been completed correctly and providing feedback to the researcher if it is required. Principal investigators or supervisors must have completed ethics training.

A data management plan (DMP) should be put in place by the researcher and be reviewed and approved by the supervisor or PI ***before*** submission of the ethics application.¹

If your application is a modification of an existing submission, or a new submission having only minor modifications to one previously granted a favourable ethical opinion (FEO), see Section A4.

¹ See the Data Management Plan (DMP) form and guidance.

Section A. Information to be provided to the Research Ethics Committee, along with Section B (if applicable)

1. The applicant	
Applicant's name	Xian Diao
Applicant's role	Student 20513832
UoN email address	scyxd6@nottingham.ac.uk
Module / course details	Undergraduate Projects [COMP3003]
Supervisor/PI's name	Susan Ali
Supervisor/PI's email address	Susan.Ali2@nottingham.ac.uk
Clinical advisor's name	N/A
Clinical advisor's email address	N/A

2. The project	
Project title	LLM-Driven Trade Communication Assistant
Project content and ethical relevance	The project develops an AI-based assistant for cross-border business communication and document generation. It uses only publicly available and synthetic text data with no human participants or personal information. The research presents minimal ethical risk and complies with the standard SOP 2.2 framework.
Proposed start date	28/10/2025
Date and version of application	28/10/2025 Version 1
Type of application	Application of an agreed SOP
Application ID (if known) ²	CS-T-3-SOP2.2-[supervisor initials]-[student initials]-[number]

3. Change log
<i>If this is a revision or re-submission, summarise how the application has been changed in response to the reviewers' comments, or delete if not applicable</i>
N/A

4. Modifications and related applications

² An ethics application is usually allocated an ID by the CS REC *after* initial submission.

*If you seek approval to modify a research project that has already received ethics approval in some way and is currently live or ongoing, or for a new research project that is very similar to one that has previously received a FEO and only contains minor modifications, please provide the application ID and describe the modifications in detail here. The reviewers will assess whether a new application is required or if this update may be appended to the original / related application. You do not need to complete the rest of this form, unless updates are also required to specific sections. If so, please list which sections have been updated and **highlight them for the reviewers' attention.***

N/A

5a. Research ethics checklist (part one)

Answer all questions:	Yes/No
a) Does the research pose any risks to the researchers, participants, culture, the environment, and/or the reputation of those involved in the research or the reputation of university? <i>For example...</i>	No
b) Does the data contain inappropriate images of the individuals involved?	No
c) Will the project involve inappropriate or unauthorised manipulation or representation of the data?	No
d) Could the data processing and reporting of the project outcomes cause psychological or social risks to the individuals involved?	No
e) Does the research involve travelling to countries/regions against the advice of the British Foreign Commonwealth Office.	No

5b. Data ethics checklist (part two)

Answer all questions:	Yes/No
Is there evidence, through a published paper and/or a license agreement and/or data collection ethics application with a favourable ethical opinion (FEO), that the dataset was:	
A) collected according to acceptable ethical standards?	Yes
B) collected with explicit consent from the participants?	Yes
C) collected in compliance with UK/EU data privacy laws?	Yes

If you have answered "no" to all questions in A5a (part 1), and "yes" to all questions in A5b (part 2), you may go to Section A7.

If you have answered "yes" to any of the questions in A5a (part 1), or "no" to any of the questions in A5b (part 2), please explain below (Section A6) why this is necessary and how you plan to deal with the ethical issues raised.

6. Research involving more than minimal risk
Explain here why it is necessary to conduct research involving more than minimal risk. Describe any risks posed to the researchers, participants, culture, the environment, and/or the reputation of those involved in the research or the reputation of the university, and what steps will be taken, or measures put in place to mitigate those risks. Describe what evidence there is that data has been collected ethically, legally and with consent, and any additional precautions that will be taken with the data. N/A

7. Purpose of the research
a) Aims and objectives of the research
<i>Briefly describe what the research is about, its aims and objectives or what it seeks to achieve, and describe the context / motivation for the research (e.g., a thorny problem in computing, a new trend, a topical issue, the aims of a funded research project, completing module assessments, etc.).</i> The project involves the development and preliminary evaluation of natural language processing systems to automatically interpret buyer enquiries, generate culturally appropriate business responses, and produce trade-related documents based on structured templates from textual data.
b) What data will be obtained and processed?
<i>Describe what data will be obtained, from whom or where, and how it will allow you to meet the aims and objectives of the research.</i> <i>Note, if your supervisor is providing the data then they should be able to provide the necessary details for section A.7 parts b), c), d) and e) and section A.8 "data subjects".</i> The dataset consists of automatically interpret buyer enquiries, generate culturally appropriate business responses, and produce trade-related documents based on structured templates from publicly available repositories and synthetic text samples. The data will be processed using publicly available repositories and synthetic text samples.
c) How will the data be obtained?
<i>Describe how the data will be obtained. Note that web crawling and screen scraping may violate intellectual property rights, terms and conditions, and user privacy.³ You must be sure, and provide evidence with this ethics application, that any data collected in these ways is in the public domain and that you process the data in ways the data subjects (the people identified in or by the data) would expect or find fair.⁴</i> The Applicant(stuent) has obtained the data from publicly available repositories and has also created synthetic text samples.
d) Permission to use the data
<i>Provide evidence the data will be or was lawfully obtained and that you are entitled to use it (e.g., online license, UoN contract reference, headed letter; you may submit supporting documentation along with this application). You cannot use special category data – inc. race or ethnicity, sexual orientation or sexual activity, political opinions, religious or philosophical beliefs, biometric identifiers, genetic or health data – without the explicit consent of the data</i>

³ <https://parissmith.co.uk/blog/web-crawling-screen-scraping-legal-position/>

⁴ <https://ico.org.uk/about-the-ico/news-and-events/news-and-blogs/2022/05/ico-fines-facial-recognition-database-company-clearview-ai-inc>

subject.⁵ You must provide evidence that explicit consent has been given if you wish to use such data.

Identify whichever option applies:

[Yes]: Data from a third form a third party or public repository:

The Applicant has obtained permission to use the data by Agreeing to the Terms of Use and open research licences provided by publicly available repositories, with all datasets released under open licences that explicitly permit reuse for research and non-commercial purposes. [Datasets – Hugging Face](#)

[No]: Data previously collected by the Applicant/Project Supervisor:

The data collection was given a favourable ethical opinion (FEO) by the [specify research ethics review board e.g., Computer Science Research Ethics Committee] as [ethics committee application/approval ID] ([specify title of the research project]). The data processing for this project will adhere to terms under which it was collected. [Attach data collection ethics documentation e.g., participant information sheet, ethics checklist, consent forms etc]

e) Constraints on use of the data

Specify on constraints placed on use of the data by the party or parties it was obtained from, if applicable

Identify all that apply:

[Yes]: The text data must not be redistributed or republished in full.

Example: Tweets must not be published in reports describing the project results, except where participants have given consent.

[Yes]: The dataset must not be reproduced or uploaded elsewhere.

Example: The dataset must not be republished online and therefore a README file will be provided to explain how to obtain the data for the purpose of reproducibility.

8. Data processing

Data subjects

Specify the categories of people the data concerns or is about (e.g., students, household members, members of staff at X company, members of the public, Twitter users, etc.)

Publicly available text data with no identifiable information about individuals.

Example: Members of Twitter aged 18 years or more and geolocated in the UK.

Pre-processing of data

i. Pre-processing procedure(s)

Specify any processing that will be done to the data before it is analysed (e.g., annotation, labelling, cleaning, etc.).

The data will be pre-processed using a standard natural language processing pipeline: text cleaning, tokenisation, normalisation, and removal of duplicate or irrelevant entries.

⁵ <https://ico.org.uk/for-organisations/guide-to-data-protection/guide-to-the-general-data-protection-regulation-gdpr/lawful-basis-for-processing/special-category-data>

	<i>Example: the data will be tokenised, part-of-speech annotated, and lemmatised before processing.</i> ii. Anonymisation / pseudonymisation applied <i>Specify how pre-processed data will be anonymised or pseudonymised if applicable (e.g., pseudonyms or alphanumerical IDs will be used instead of real names, identifying information will be removed from free text responses, etc.)</i> <i>Identify whichever applies:</i> [Yes]: The data is already pseudonymised, i.e. subjects are identified by a dataset-specific participant ID. [No]: The data will be pseudonymised using the following procedure [list steps taken to pseudonymise the dataset]. <i>Identify all that apply:</i> [Yes]: textual data is already anonymised (i.e. participants are not re-identifiable). [No]: [Data: specify data type(s), e.g. textual data] will be anonymised using the following procedure [list steps taken to anonymise the data]. <i>Example: the data will be anonymised using Microsoft's Presidio library available at https://github.com/microsoft/presidio</i> [No]: [Data: specify data type, e.g. image, audio] cannot be anonymized before analysis because [specify reasons]. [Specify any restrictions on the publication of identifying information in reports if applicable e.g., <i>images will not be published in reports except for participants who consented to this</i>]
Data analysis	<i>Specify the analytic method(s), procedure(s), protocol(s) or technique(s) that will be used to process and analyse the data. Insert a URL to an example of each (or similar where a new method, procedure, protocol or technique is used).⁶</i> The text data will be analysed using Transformer-based NLP models implemented with PyTorch and Hugging Face Transformers. https://huggingface.co/docs/transformers <i>Example: we will train transformer-based text classifiers using PyTorch and pretrained BERT embeddings.</i>
Data sharing	<i>Specify any third-party recipients or services the data is shared with and how they are GDPR compliant and protect the data</i> N/A
Data storage	<i>Specify the data asset's name, location and owner.</i>

⁶ See, for example, [https:// ...](https://...) insert link to example of method, procedure, protocol, technique

	[Dataset name: LLM based assistant salesman] [Dataset location: Stored securely within the University of Nottingham O365 OneDrive (private project folder, accessible to the applicant and supervisor)] [Dataset owner: Susan Ali]
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9. Provision of information to data subjects	
Data protection law requires that when data is NOT obtained directly from data subjects they be provided with the information in Section B within 1 month of the data being obtained, unless: a) The individuals concerned already have the information b) Providing the information to the individuals concerned would be impossible c) It would involve a disproportionate effort to provide the information to individuals	
Do the individuals concerned already have the information in Section B (or equivalent)?	No
<i>If "Yes", please specify how they were provided with this information below. The following items are then Not Applicable.</i> [If yes, explain how, e.g. that the current project falls within the range of use described to participants when the data was collected]	
If the individuals concerned do NOT have the information in Section B (or equivalent), is it possible to provide them with it?	NA
If the individuals concerned do NOT have the information in Section B (or equivalent) but it is possible to provide them with it, is the effort involved proportionate to the research? <i>If "Yes" then you must ensure that the information in Section B is provided to the individuals concerned.</i>	NA
If the individuals concerned do NOT have the information in Section B (or equivalent), and it is not possible or proportionate to the research to provide it, state why: <i>Identify whichever applies:</i> [No]: The individuals concerned already have the information in Section B (or equivalent) [Yes]: It is not possible to provide this information to individuals in the dataset because the data are publicly available and contain no identifiable contact details. [Yes]: It is not proportionate to provide this information to individuals in the dataset because the data are fully anonymised, involve no personal information, and pose minimal ethical risk.	

10. Further information
<i>Please provide any further information which may affect consideration of the ethics involved in the proposed research, e.g., the nature and sensitivity of the data, unusual circumstances, use of AI components, software analytics or biometric software used to</i>

process data, etc., including any services not made available by the University and their data use and retention policies. Please include any supporting documentation with this application.

The transformer-based NLP models will be implemented on local device or on University-approved Google Colab instances. Only anonymised/synthetic data will be used; no personal data will be uploaded to cloud services.

11. Applicant declaration	
Please confirm each of the following statements:	Yes/No
I confirm that I've completed all variable sections in Parts A and B (indicated by the highlighted text) to reflect my project	[Yes]
I confirm that I have not changed any of the fixed sections	[Yes]
I confirm that the data does not contain inappropriate images of the individuals involved.	[Yes]
I confirm that the project will not involve inappropriate or unauthorised manipulation or representation of the audio/video data.	[Yes]
I confirm that the data processing and reporting of the project outcomes will not cause psychological or social risks to the individuals involved.	[Yes]
I confirm that this work will NOT involve making automated decisions that have legal effect or significantly impact participants.	[Yes]
The research is minimal risk (see section A.5)	[Yes]
The data has been obtained lawfully	[Yes]
The data management plan (DMP) form has been completed	[Yes]
I confirm that I will conduct the work in accordance with the description here.	[Yes]
Applicant	Xian Diao
Date	28/10/2025

12. Supervisor/PI declaration	
Please confirm each of the following statements:	Yes/No
I have completed ethics training	Yes
The proposed research complies with the UoN Code of Research Conduct and Research Ethics	Yes
I have reviewed and approve the DMP <i>The supervisor/PI must refer the DMP to CS REC for approval if the answer is NO to Sections 6.2, 7.4, 7.5 or 8.2. If the applicant and the PI are the same, the DMP should be submitted with this application for review by CS REC.</i>	Yes

I confirm that the research is minimal risk and that the application complies with the SOP		Yes
Supervisor/PI	Susan Ali	
Date	02/11/2025	

Section B. Information to be provided to data subject

Notice of personal data processing for research purposes

The School of Computer Science, University of Nottingham has obtained personal data from **enter source** for use in research.

Data obtained

The dataset consists of automatically interpret buyer enquiries, generate culturally appropriate business responses, and produce trade-related documents based on structured templates from publicly available repositories and synthetic text samples. The data will be processed using publicly available repositories and synthetic text samples.

Aims and objectives of the research

The project involves the development and preliminary evaluation of natural language processing systems to automatically interpret buyer enquiries, generate culturally appropriate business responses, and produce trade-related documents based on structured templates from textual data.

Purpose(s) of processing

Data collected during the research that identifies you may be:

- Analysed to meet the aims and objectives described above
- Reviewed and discussed in supervision sessions between researchers and their supervisors or in research meetings between members of the research team, including project partners
- Used in scientific works, including presentations, reports and publications stored in databases and posted online and in marketing materials that promote the research and its findings

Automated decision-making

Data will not be used for automated decision making, i.e. wholly automated decisions that have legal effect or significantly impact participants.

Lawful basis of processing

We collect personal data under the terms of the University of Nottingham's Royal Charter and in our capacity as a teaching and research body to advance education and learning. We thus process your data on the legal basis that our research is in the public interest, we have legitimate interests and / or that you consent to data processing in freely and voluntarily participating in our research activities.

Retention of your data

Your data may be archived for future use for public interest, scientific or historical research purposes or statistical purposes, subject to the implementation of technical and organisational measures that safeguard your data, your legal rights and your freedoms.

Disclosure of your data to another party

Data will not be shared with another party.

Ethics approval

The use of your data for the purposes specified above follow a standard protocol agreed by the School of Computer Science Research Ethics Committee (CS REC), SOP2.2 and has been reviewed by my project supervisor, Susan Ali.

You can contact the CS REC by email at Ps-cs-ethicsadmin@exmail.nottingham.ac.uk

Our contact details

School of Computer Science
University of Nottingham
Jubilee Campus
Wollaton Road
Nottingham NG8 1BB
United Kingdom

Our Data Protection Officer

Data Protection Officer
Legal Services
A5 Trent Building
University of Nottingham
University Park
Nottingham NG7 2RD
United Kingdom

Your rights

You have the legal right:

- To be informed about the collection and use of personal data (as per this notice).
- To access and receive a copy of your personal data, and other supplementary information, on request.
- To object to and restrict data processing if you think we are not complying with data protection law, and to rectify inaccuracies.
- To be forgotten, i.e., to have your personal data erased.
- To data portability and to obtain your data in an accessible and machine-readable format if appropriate, or to transfer your data to another organisation if technically feasible.
- To complain to the Information Commissioner's Office: <https://ico.org.uk/make-a-complaint>